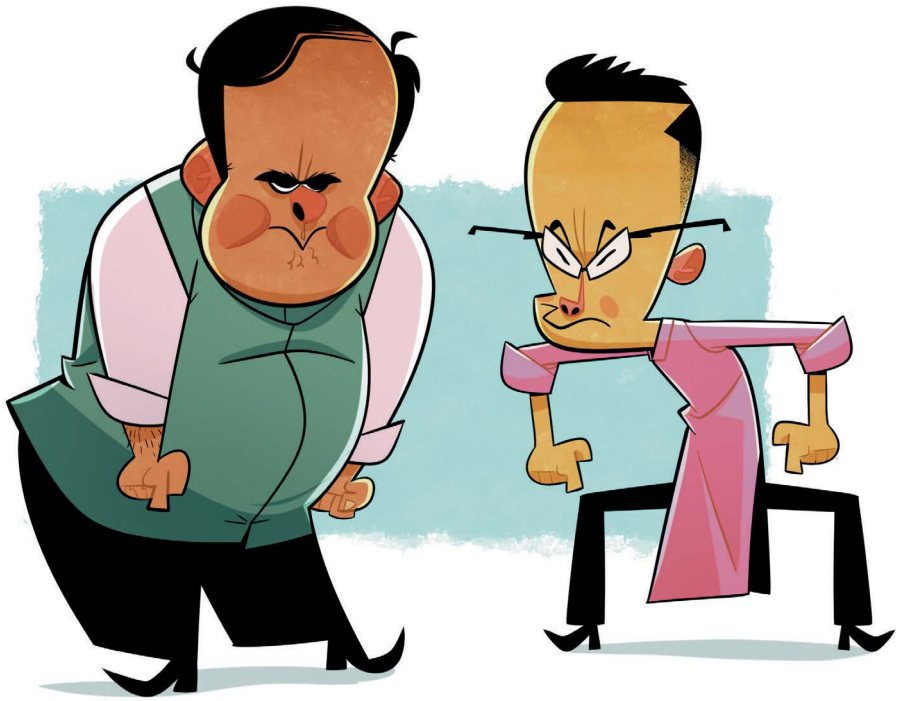


Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

ASSAM ANGLE IN JHARKHAND

While all eyes are glued to the main battle between the two heavyweight alliances—the NDA and INDIA—in Jharkhand, an interesting subplot is developing elsewhere—the showdown between two rival Assamese politicians. Back in June, the BJP appointed Assam CM Himanta Biswa Sarma as one of the election bigwigs for Jharkhand. Four months on, the Congress hit back, tapping Assam MP Gaurav Gogoi to join their trio of senior strategists for the state. This isn't the first time Sarma and Gogoi have crossed swords this year. Sarma, the BJP's brash campaign czar, took aim at Gogoi in Jorhat in the Lok Sabha polls, marshalling half his ministry and the party's full might. Gogoi, with his understated campaign, kept his cool and clinched the seat, leaving Sarma's forces to lick their wounds. Now for Round 2 in Jharkhand. Will Sarma finally have his revenge?

A Devoted Pitch



Reaching out, bowing before them, touching their feet, Odisha's first BJP CM **Mohan Charan Majhi** made sure people took note of his efforts to appease the Habisyalis—women devotees who go on a gruelling month-long fast in the Hindu month of Kartik before converging on Puri for its culmination. Majhi even directed local authorities to prepare accommodation for some 2,500 pilgrims, and the Puri administration dutifully put out a video showing them settled comfortably in their government-arranged lodgings. The CM himself was there on Oct. 20, plugging his government's women-focused Subhadra Yojana too in his speech. Nothing says "devotion" quite like a well-timed policy plug.

MINISTER ON MUTE

Tamil Nadu's electricity, prohibition and excise minister, **V. Senthil Balaji**, once the media's go-to person for stinging comment, has been uncharacteristically quiet since his Supreme Court-approved bail on Sept. 26. Though reinstated as cabinet minister by CM M.K. Stalin three days later, Balaji now communicates only via cautious press release. Change of heart, or just strategic silence? Insiders say he has been advised to keep a low profile until the courts have cleared the allegations in a cash-for-jobs scam and ED its money-laundering probe. Mum's the word till then.



PTI

Kaushik Deka with Arkamoy Datta Majumdar and Amarnath K. Menon



To Heir or Not To

One still doesn't know why Sikkim chief minister **Prem Singh Tamang (Golay)**'s wife Krishna Kumari Rai quit as Namchi-Singhithang MLA a day after taking oath. Now, as voters prepare for a bypoll to Namchi-Singhithang as well as Soreng-Chakung—the seat the CM vacated after winning Rhenock too—the pressure is building on the ruling Sikkim Krantikari Morcha (SKM) to field Aditya, Golay's eldest son from his first marriage and a former MLA, but the CM himself is not so sure. He does not want to be seen as indulging in nepotism, it seems. This when the SKM has 31 out of 32 seats in the assembly; even the lone Sikkim Democratic Front member is on their side. Perception matters more than reality in politics.



THE BIGGER RAO

The crown prince of Bharat Rashtra Samithi—party patriarch K. Chandrashekar Rao's son **K.T. Rama Rao**—and the family's go-to crisis manager—T. Harish Rao—are in a full-blown show of flexing their political muscle against each other. What began as a bit of oneupmanship between the two has exploded into a no-holds-barred power struggle. KCR's being in hibernation after double poll debacles isn't helping matters either.